

SOME LOVE STORIES ARE WRITTEN IN WORDS.
OTHERS ARE WRITTEN IN SILENCE.

THE *Silent* LOVE

A STORY OF UNHEARD WORDS
AND UNDERSTOOD SILENCES



Mouna.



You don't have to
say it...
I will understand
anyway.



Sunday.
Always. ♥

A love story by Lijo Paul M E

THE SILENT LOVE

A STORY OF LOVE, FAITH & SILENCE

By Lijo Paul M E



T H E S I L E N T L O V E

A STORY OF LOVE, FAITH & SILENCE

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First Edition

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DEDICATED

To every soul
who searched
for love
in the loudest places,
only to discover
that the most beautiful love stories
arrive quietly.

"I spent years searching
for someone
who would understand my words.

Destiny introduced me
to someone
who understood my silence."

A L E T T E R B E F O R E W E B E G I N

Dear Reader,

If this book has somehow found its way into your hands, perhaps it arrived at exactly the right moment.

Maybe you're here because you love love stories.

Maybe you're searching for hope.

Or maybe you're simply looking for a story that feels a little like home.

Whatever brought you here, thank you.

The pages you're about to read are filled with ordinary moments that quietly become unforgettable—college corridors, rainy evenings, Sunday mornings, songs played on an old guitar, friendships that become family, and a city that changes lives in ways no one expects.

At the heart of it all is a simple truth.

Love isn't measured by the words we speak.

It's measured by the effort we're willing to make for someone else.

This story belongs to everyone who has ever waited, hoped, prayed, searched, or believed that somewhere in this vast world, there is someone who will understand them exactly as they are.

As you read, don't rush.

Stay with the little moments.

Listen to the silence.

Because sometimes, that's where the most beautiful conversations happen.

I hope this story makes you smile.

I hope it reminds you of someone.

And above all, I hope it stays with you long after you've turned the final page.

Welcome to our story.

With gratitude,

LIJO

P R O L O G U E

2:17 A.M.

*"Every love story begins somewhere.
Ours began with a YouTube video."*

Bengaluru

The room was silent.

Not the peaceful kind of silence, but the sort that lingered long after everyone else had fallen asleep. The ticking wall clock sounded louder than usual, and the pale blue glow from an old phone resting beside Jo's pillow painted faint patterns across the ceiling.

Sleep had given up on him hours ago.

He reached for his phone, unlocked it with a tired sigh, and opened YouTube.

The app loaded instantly.

Waiting for him was a single recommendation.

5 Easy Ways to Impress Your Crush.

Jo stared at the title for a long moment before a quiet laugh escaped him.

"Really?"

The title sat there, almost mocking him.

5 Easy Ways to Impress Your Crush.

It had nearly four million views.

"Well," he murmured to himself, "at least I'm not the only idiot."

A faint smile crept across his face as he tapped the screen.

The cheerful intro music played, followed by a man with perfect hair, perfect teeth, and an unreasonable amount of confidence.

"Welcome back, everyone!" the man beamed. "Today, I'm going to tell you the five easiest ways to make your crush notice you."

Jo leaned back against the wall and listened as though he had just enrolled in the most important class of his life.

"Rule number one," the presenter announced, raising a finger dramatically, "confidence."
Jo paused the video.

He opened the Notes app and typed a single word.
Confidence.

He stared at it for a moment before underlining it twice.
"Easy enough," he whispered.

The video resumed.

"Rule number two—find out what they like."

Another pause.

Another note.

Know her favourite songs.

He smiled to himself.

That one, at least, sounded possible.

"Rule number three," the presenter continued, "do something they'll never forget."

Jo didn't pause the video this time.

Instead, his eyes drifted toward the old acoustic guitar resting quietly against the corner of his room.

Its wooden body was scratched in places, and one of the tuning pegs had been replaced after an unfortunate fall two years earlier. It wasn't expensive, but it had been with him through every important moment of his teenage years.

Whenever life became too loud, he played.

Whenever words refused to come, he played.

Whenever he was happy, confused, heartbroken, or simply tired...

he played.

Music had always understood him before people ever did.

A slow smile spread across his face.

"Maybe that's it."

He looked at the guitar for another moment before closing the video.

Outside, rain continued to tap gently against the window.

Inside, a dream had quietly begun.

He picked up the guitar and rested it on his lap.

His fingers found the familiar strings almost by instinct, brushing across them gently until the room filled with a soft melody.

The notes weren't perfect.

Neither was he.

But that had never stopped him from playing.

Some songs reminded him of rainy evenings.

Some reminded him of home.

Some reminded him of people he hadn't met yet.

He often wondered whether somewhere in the world there was someone listening to the very same song, waiting for a story neither of them knew had already begun.

The thought made him smile.

He placed the guitar back beside his bed, switched off the lamp, and lay down once more.

Before closing his eyes, he whispered a quiet prayer.

"Wherever she is...

I hope she's smiling tonight."

Within minutes, sleep finally found him.

Neither of them knew it yet.

But destiny had already started writing the first page of their story.

CHAPTER ONE

THE BOY WHO BELIEVED IN LOVE

The first day of school after the summer holidays always carried a strange kind of excitement.

Freshly painted classroom walls.

New textbooks that still smelled of ink.

Polished black shoes that would lose their shine before the week ended.

And students who had somehow managed to grow taller in just two months.

For Jo, however, the first day wasn't about new notebooks or new teachers.

It was about seeing familiar faces again.

There was something comforting about walking through the old school gate, hearing the morning bell echo across the campus, and realizing that, despite the passing years, some things never really changed.

The security guard still greeted every student with the same warm smile.

The canteen still smelled of hot samosas before the first period.

And the banyan tree in the middle of the courtyard still stood proudly, watching generations of students grow up beneath its shade.

Jo adjusted the strap of his school bag and smiled.

Some places don't just become memories.

They become part of who you are.

The assembly bell rang, and within moments the courtyard was filled with rows of students dressed in neatly ironed uniforms.

The morning sun wasn't harsh yet. It spilled gently across the open ground, making the school crest on every pocket glimmer for a brief moment.

Jo stood somewhere in the middle of his class, trying his best to sing the school anthem while secretly wondering what the canteen menu would be for lunch.

Priorities, he often believed, were important.

"Stand straight," whispered someone behind him.

"I am standing straight."

"You've been leaning for the last five minutes."

"I call this a relaxed posture."

A muffled laugh escaped from the line behind.

Without turning around, Jo already knew who it was.

Arjun.

Some friendships begin with introductions.

Theirs had begun with detention.

Arjun had an answer for everything.

Whether it was a mathematics problem, a football argument, or a lecture from the principal, he somehow managed to respond with the same confidence.

Most of the time, he was completely wrong.

That had never stopped him.

"You finished the holiday homework?" Arjun whispered as the principal began addressing the students.

Jo looked ahead.

"No."

"I copied yours."

"You what?"

"Relax," Arjun grinned. "Your handwriting is much better than mine."

Jo sighed.

"You know that's exactly why the teacher will catch us."

"Details."

Before Jo could reply, a sharp voice echoed across the assembly ground.

"You two..."

The principal lowered his glasses.

"Would you like to continue this conversation in my office?"

The entire school burst into laughter.

Arjun smiled.

Jo closed his eyes.

It was only the first day.

And they were already in trouble.

The morning assembly finally came to an end.

As soon as the principal stepped away from the podium, the disciplined rows dissolved into cheerful chaos. Students rushed toward their classrooms, laughing, pushing one another, exchanging stories about their holidays as though two months had been two years.

Jo and Arjun were no different.

"I still think he was looking only at you," Arjun said, adjusting his tie.

"He was definitely looking at both of us."

"No, no. I was just standing beside you for emotional support."

Jo laughed. "You're unbelievable."

"I've been told."

The corridor echoed with footsteps as hundreds of students climbed the staircase at once. Teachers tried to restore order, but the excitement of the first day was impossible to control.

For Jo, school had never been about classrooms.

It had always been about moments like these.

Their classroom hadn't changed much.

The same green chalkboard stood at the front.

The same wooden benches carried years of carved initials and unfinished doodles.

Even the ceiling fan above Jo's seat still made the same irritating clicking sound every few seconds.

"Home sweet home," Arjun declared dramatically as he dropped his bag onto the last bench.

"You say that every year."

"And every year I'm right."

Before Jo could reply, another voice interrupted them.

"Move."

They turned.

Daniel stood there with two packets of chips tucked under his arm and an expression that suggested he'd already caused trouble somewhere else.

"You bought snacks before the first period?" Jo asked.

Daniel shrugged.

"Preparation is the key to success."

"For what?"

"Survival."

A few moments later, another familiar face walked through the classroom door.

Kiran.

Unlike the others, he entered quietly, greeted the teacher with a polite smile, and took his seat without saying much.

"Morning," Jo called.

Kiran nodded.

"Morning."

"How was your holiday?"

"Peaceful."

"That's all?"

Kiran smiled.

"It was enough."

Daniel leaned closer to Jo and whispered, "One day he'll write an autobiography."

"What'll it be called?"

Daniel didn't even hesitate.

"It Was Enough."

Jo burst into laughter.

Even Kiran couldn't stop himself from smiling.

That was the thing about them.

No matter how different they were...

they somehow fit together perfectly.

The first period had barely begun when their class teacher walked in with a stack of attendance sheets.

"Good morning, everyone."

"Good morning, ma'am."

"I hope all of you enjoyed your holidays."

A few students nodded enthusiastically.

"Good. Because from today onward, you'll wish they had lasted longer."

The entire class groaned.

She smiled knowingly before opening the attendance register.

As names echoed across the room, Jo rested his chin on his hand and looked out the window.

Beyond the classroom, sunlight filtered through the branches of the old rain tree. A gentle breeze carried the distant sound of students practising for Independence Day celebrations.

He smiled to himself.

Some people looked forward to weekends.

Jo looked forward to memories.

The first week of school passed exactly the way first weeks always did—slowly.

Teachers revised old lessons, students pretended to pay attention, and notebooks remained suspiciously clean. Everyone knew the real studying would begin next Monday. Until then, school was simply finding its rhythm again.

For Jo and his friends, every break period ended in the same place.

The old rain tree near the basketball court.

No one had assigned it to them.

No one even remembered who had found it first.

But somehow, it had become theirs.

Every afternoon, four school bags landed beneath its shade, followed by four boys who believed the world could wait until the lunch bell ended.

"I've decided something," Daniel announced between bites of a samosa.

Arjun looked up.

"That's usually dangerous."

"I'm going to become famous."

"Doing what?"

"I don't know yet."

Jo laughed.

"Solid plan."

"I'm serious."

Daniel pointed at each of them.

"One day, people are going to remember us."

"For what?" Kiran asked.

Daniel leaned back against the tree and smiled.

"For being unforgettable."

For a brief moment...

none of them laughed.

Because deep inside,

they all hoped he was right.

The rain tree had witnessed countless conversations.

Arguments over football.

Last-minute homework discussions.

Dreams that changed every other week.

One afternoon, it was engineering.

The next, it was becoming musicians.

By Friday, someone wanted to be an astronaut.

At sixteen, the future changed as often as the weather.

"What about you?" Arjun asked, turning to Jo.

"What do you want to become?"

Jo thought for a moment.

"I don't know."

"Come on."

"There has to be something."

He looked up through the branches, where patches of blue sky peeked through the leaves.

"I just want to be happy."

The others fell silent.

It wasn't the answer they had expected.

But somehow...

it felt like the most honest one.

That evening, as the final bell echoed across the campus, students poured out through the school gates like a river finding its course.

Buses lined the road.

Parents waited patiently under umbrellas.

Friends promised to meet online later that night to "study," knowing full well they would spend more time talking than revising.

Jo adjusted his backpack and began the walk home.

He always preferred walking.

It gave him time to think.

Time to notice things most people rushed past.

The old man who sold roasted peanuts outside the school.

The little girl who waved at every passing bus.

The stray dog that faithfully waited near the tea stall every evening.

To Jo, stories lived everywhere.

You just had to slow down long enough to see them.

CHAPTER TWO

SIX STRINGS

The following Monday, just before the lunch bell, a notice appeared on the classroom board.

Cultural Club Auditions.

Music.

Dance.

Drama.

Mimicry.

Instrumental Performance.

Students crowded around the notice before the teacher had even finished pinning it to the board.

"I told you!" Daniel exclaimed. "This is my chance."

"For what?" Arjun asked.

"Fame."

"You've been saying that for three years."

"And one day, I'll be right."

Jo smiled but didn't join the crowd.

Instead, he stood by the window, reading the notice from a distance.

There, tucked between Solo Singing and Group Choir, was the one line that caught his attention.

Instrumental Performance – Guitar.

Something stirred inside him.

"You should participate."

Jo turned around.

It was Kiran.

"I don't know."

"You've been playing since you were twelve."

"Playing at home is different."

Kiran folded his arms.

"You're scared."

"I'm not scared."

"Then prove it."

Before Jo could answer, Daniel appeared out of nowhere.

"What's happening?"

"Jo's pretending he doesn't want to perform."

Daniel looked at Jo.

Then at the notice.

Then back at Jo.

"Oh, absolutely not."

Jo sighed.

"I hate all of you."

"No," Daniel corrected with a grin.

"You love us."

"What?"

"You're participating."

"I never said I was."

"You didn't have to."

Arjun walked over, glanced at the notice, and smiled.

"I think we've all agreed."

That evening, Jo reached home earlier than usual.

His school bag landed on the sofa.

His shoes remained exactly where he kicked them off.

He walked straight into his room.

The guitar rested against the wall, exactly where he had left it the night before.

He picked it up carefully.

Ran his fingers across the strings.

The familiar vibration settled his racing thoughts.

There was something comforting about holding it.

It never judged him.

It never expected perfection.

It simply waited.

Patiently.

For him to play.

His fingers moved almost instinctively.

One chord.

Then another.

Soon, the room filled with music that belonged to no audience.

There were no judges.

No applause.

No expectations.

Just Jo...

and six strings that somehow understood every emotion he couldn't explain.

His mother paused outside the half-open door.

She didn't interrupt.

She simply listened.

A small smile appeared on her face.

She had heard that melody countless times before.

But every time her son played...

it sounded a little different.

Because every time...

he had grown a little more.

The auditions were only four days away.

For the first time in years, Jo found himself practising with a purpose.

Every evening, his room echoed with the same melody. His fingers stumbled over difficult chords, paused, and tried again. Some notes sounded perfect. Others didn't.

He never complained.

Music had taught him something long before life did.

The most beautiful songs were never played perfectly the first time.

"You're going to wear out those strings," his father joked one evening as he peeked through the half-open door.

Jo looked up and smiled.

"They're holding up better than I am."

His father chuckled.

"Nervous?"

"A little."

He nodded knowingly.

"That means it matters."

By Wednesday, the entire school seemed to be talking about the auditions.

Someone was practising a dance routine in the corridor.

A group of singers occupied the music room during lunch break.

Even the art club had transformed an empty classroom into a workshop filled with paint, charts, and laughter.

The campus felt different.

Alive.

Jo stood outside the music room, guitar case in hand, watching students walk in and out.

His heartbeat quickened.

"Still thinking of backing out?"

Arjun appeared beside him with two cups of tea from the canteen.

Jo accepted one gratefully.

"I don't know."

"You've said that five times today."

"And I'll probably say it five more."

Arjun laughed.

"Good."

"Good?"

"It means you're taking this seriously."

That afternoon, their music teacher entered the classroom carrying a stack of audition forms.

"Anyone interested in participating can collect one after class."

Almost every hand went up.

Daniel raised both.

The class burst into laughter.

"You can only take one," the teacher reminded him.

"I have two talents, ma'am."

"You've shown neither so far."

Even the teacher laughed.

When the bell rang, students rushed towards the desk.

Jo stayed seated.

He watched the crowd for a moment before quietly walking forward.

The teacher handed him a form.

"I've been waiting for you to take one."

He looked surprised.

"You knew I would?"

She smiled.

"I've heard you practising after school."

Jo blinked.

"You have?"

"The walls of the music room are thinner than you think."

For the first time that day...

his nervousness turned into excitement.

Practice became part of his routine.

School.

Home.

Homework.

Guitar.

Repeat.

His fingertips grew sore.

His confidence grew slowly.

Every evening ended the same way.

He would place the guitar back against the wall, look at it for a second, and whisper,

"We'll get it right tomorrow."

The guitar, of course, never answered.

It didn't need to.

Some companions speak.

Others simply stay.

The day of the auditions arrived sooner than Jo expected.

From the moment he entered school, the campus felt different.

Music drifted through open classroom windows. Someone was rehearsing a dance routine near the auditorium, while another group argued passionately over whose turn it was to use the microphone.

The entire school seemed louder than usual.

Except for Jo.

He barely noticed any of it.

His guitar case felt heavier than ever as he walked down the corridor.

"Relax," Arjun said, nudging his shoulder. "You're carrying a guitar, not a bomb."

"I'm aware."

"Then why do you look like you're about to write your final exam?"

Jo laughed softly.

"Because this somehow feels worse."

The auditorium was already filling up.

Students chatted excitedly while teachers hurried across the stage, adjusting microphones and arranging chairs.

Jo found a seat near the back and rested his guitar beside him.

He took a deep breath.

Another.

Then another.

"You know," Daniel said, dropping into the seat next to him, "if you breathe any deeper, you'll pass out before your performance."

"I appreciate your support."

"I know."

Daniel smiled.

"It's one of my best qualities."

Before Jo could answer, the auditorium doors opened again.

A small group of students walked in.

Without thinking...

Jo looked up.

CHAPTER THREE

THE FIRST GLANCE

She wasn't trying to stand out.

She wasn't surrounded by friends, and she wasn't laughing loudly or looking around the room. She simply walked in, carrying a notebook against her chest, quietly searching for an empty seat.

The morning sunlight slipped through the high windows, catching the edge of her neatly tied hair for just a moment before she disappeared into the crowd.

Jo watched her sit down three rows ahead.

That was all.

There was no dramatic music, no slow motion, no fireworks. Just an ordinary moment that somehow stayed with him.

He didn't know her name.

He didn't know which class she belonged to.

He didn't even know whether she had noticed him looking at her.

But for the rest of the afternoon, he found himself remembering that moment.

Not her face exactly.

Not even the way she looked.

Just the feeling of having noticed someone for the first time.

And, somehow, that felt important.

The audition continued around him.

Someone walked onto the stage and began a dance performance. A few students near the back started whispering, earning an immediate warning glance from one of the teachers.

Jo barely noticed.

His attention kept drifting toward the girl three rows ahead.

"Who are you looking at?"

Arjun's voice suddenly appeared beside him.

Jo immediately turned toward the stage.

"No one."

Arjun raised an eyebrow.

"That was a very convincing no one."

"I was just looking around."

"Of course."

Daniel leaned across from the other side.

"What's happening?"

"Nothing," Jo said.

Daniel followed Jo's gaze.

Then he looked back at him.

A slow smile appeared on his face.

"Oh."

Jo frowned.

"What?"

"I know that look."

"What look?"

"The look people get right before they start doing something incredibly embarrassing."

Arjun laughed.

Jo shook his head.

"You both are idiots."

"Maybe," Daniel said, settling back into his seat. "But I'm usually right."

By the time the audition ended, the investigation had already begun.

Four sixteen-year-old boys had somehow decided that finding a girl's name required the seriousness of a criminal investigation.

"So," Arjun said as they walked out of the auditorium, "what do we know?"

"She's probably in tenth," Daniel said.

"Probably?"

"I saw the colour of her ID card."

Jo looked at him. "That's your evidence?"

Daniel nodded proudly.

"I've worked with less."

Kiran shook his head.

"You've never worked."

"Details."

Jo laughed.

They reached the staircase just as the girl walked past them.

For a second, Jo considered saying something.

Anything.

Even a simple hello.

But before he could gather the courage, she disappeared into the crowd.

Daniel looked at him.

"Tomorrow?"

Jo sighed.

"Tomorrow."

The next morning, Jo arrived at school earlier than usual.

Arjun noticed immediately.

"You've never voluntarily arrived this early."

Jo adjusted his bag.

"I woke up early."

"At six-thirty?"

"Yes."

"Without an alarm?"

Jo hesitated.

"...Maybe."

Daniel looked at Kiran.

"This is serious."

Kiran smiled.

"Very."

Jo ignored them and glanced toward the corridor.

She wasn't there.

The first bell rang.

Still nothing.

He told himself it didn't matter.

He opened his notebook and tried to concentrate on the lesson.

Five minutes later, he looked at the door again.

Arjun caught him.

"You're not subtle."

"I'm waiting for the teacher."

"The teacher has been here for ten minutes."

Jo looked down at his notebook.

"Right."

She finally appeared during the second break.

Jo was sitting beneath the rain tree with his friends when she crossed the courtyard.

Daniel noticed her first.

He nudged Jo.

Jo looked up.

Their eyes met.

For just a moment, everything else seemed to disappear.

Then she smiled.

Jo smiled back.

She continued walking.

That was it.

No conversation.

No introduction.

Nothing that would have meant anything to anyone else.

But Jo couldn't stop smiling.

Arjun leaned against the tree.

"You're gone."

"I'm not."

"You smiled at a girl."

"People smile."

"Not like that."

Daniel laughed.

Jo shook his head.

"You both are impossible."

Maybe they were.

But somewhere between that first glance and that tiny smile, something had begun.

Jo just didn't know what to call it yet.

CHAPTER FOUR

A LITTLE CLOSER

Over the next few days, Jo discovered that having a crush was surprisingly exhausting.

He found reasons to walk past her classroom.

He suddenly became very interested in the library.

He even started taking the longer route to the canteen because, according to Daniel, "destiny needed more opportunities."

"You know she doesn't know you're doing all this, right?" Kiran asked one afternoon.

Jo looked offended.

"I'm not doing anything."

Daniel raised an eyebrow.

"You've walked past her classroom four times today."

"I like walking."

"Of course you do."

Jo laughed.

Maybe it was ridiculous.

Maybe it was.

But at sixteen, ridiculous things often felt important.

And Jo was beginning to learn that sometimes, the smallest moments could make an ordinary day feel extraordinary.

Eventually, Jo learned her name.

It wasn't through some dramatic confession or secret investigation.

It happened during a completely ordinary afternoon.

She was standing near the notice board with two of her classmates when someone called out to her.

"Hey, Ananya!"

Jo heard it from across the corridor.

He looked up immediately.

Ananya.

He repeated the name silently.

Once.

Twice.

As though he needed to make sure he wouldn't forget it.

Daniel appeared beside him.

"So?"

Jo smiled.

"I know her name."

Daniel grinned.

"Congratulations."

"For what?"

"You've completed Level One."

"What's Level Two?"

"Talking to her."

Jo's smile disappeared.

"Let's not get ahead of ourselves."

The following Monday, Jo stood outside the music room with his guitar case hanging from his shoulder.

The annual cultural programme was only a few days away, and the school was beginning to feel unusually busy. Students rehearsed in every available space, while music, laughter and nervous conversations filled the corridors.

"You look nervous," Arjun said.

Jo glanced at him. "I'm not."

"You've been staring at that guitar for five minutes."

Jo smiled. "Maybe I'm thinking."

"About?"

Before Jo could answer, the music room door opened.

"Jo?" the teacher called. "You're next."

He took a breath and walked inside.

The rehearsal wasn't perfect. He missed a chord halfway through the song and had to start the section again.

Daniel, watching from the back, whispered, "Professional."

Jo gave him a warning look.

The teacher laughed. "Again, Jo."

This time, he played it perfectly.

When the final chord faded, she nodded.

"Much better."

Jo smiled.

Maybe he had never been afraid of performing.

Maybe he had simply been afraid of wanting something to go well.

The rehearsal went better than Jo expected.

By the time he stepped into the corridor, most of his nervousness had disappeared. He packed his guitar and started walking toward the courtyard.

Then he saw her.

Ananya was standing near the library with two of her classmates, laughing about something.

Jo slowed down.

He could have kept walking.

Instead, he remembered what his friends had told him.

Just say hello.

Ananya looked up.

Their eyes met.

Jo took a breath.

"Hi."

She smiled.

"Hi."

That was it.

She turned back toward her friends, and Jo continued walking.

He had imagined their first conversation a hundred different ways.

None of them had been this simple.

Somehow, he liked it better that way.

At the end of the corridor, Daniel was waiting.

He looked at Jo and grinned.

"Level Two."

Jo laughed.

"Don't start."

After that, things became a little easier.

Jo and Ananya didn't suddenly become close. They didn't start talking every day or sitting together between classes.

It was smaller than that.

A smile when they passed each other in the corridor.

A quiet "hi" near the library.

Sometimes, a few words about class or the upcoming programme.

Nothing important enough for anyone else to notice.

But Jo noticed every little thing.

One afternoon, he was leaving the music room when Ananya stopped him.

"You're performing at the programme, right?"

Jo looked at her, surprised.

"Yeah."

"I heard you practising."

He smiled.

"Was it that bad?"

She laughed.

"No. It was actually good."

For some reason, that compliment stayed with him much longer than it should have.

"Thanks," he said.

Ananya smiled.

"Good luck."

Then she walked away.

Jo stood there for a moment, smiling to himself.

The day of the cultural programme arrived sooner than Jo expected.

The school was louder than usual. Students moved between classrooms carrying costumes, instruments and last-minute decorations.

Jo stood backstage with his guitar, listening to the crowd beyond the curtain.

His hands felt cold.

"You nervous?" Daniel asked.

"A little."

"Good."

Jo looked at him.

"Why is that good?"

"Means you care."

Before Jo could reply, his name was announced.

He took a breath and stepped onto the stage.

The lights were brighter than he expected.

For a moment, he couldn't see anything beyond them.

Then he looked toward the audience.

And there she was.

Ananya was sitting a few rows from the front.

She smiled when their eyes met.

Jo smiled back.

Then he placed his fingers on the strings.

And began to play.

The first chord rang through the auditorium.

Then another.

Jo's hands slowly stopped shaking.

The crowd disappeared behind the music, and for those few minutes, there was only the guitar, his voice, and the song he had practised so many times in his room.

He wasn't thinking about the judges anymore.

Or the teachers.

Or even Ananya.

He was simply enjoying the moment.

When the final note faded, the auditorium filled with applause.

Jo smiled and looked toward the audience.

Ananya was clapping too.

For some reason, that was the applause he noticed most.

As he stepped off the stage, Daniel was waiting backstage.

He grabbed Jo by the shoulders.

"Bro!"

Jo laughed.

"What?"

"You actually did it."

Jo looked back toward the stage.

"Yeah."

For the first time, he understood why music had always felt like home.

CHAPTER FIVE

THE FIRST LESSON

After the programme, Jo found Ananya near the side entrance of the auditorium.

"Hey," she said.

"Hey."

She smiled. "You played really well."

"Thanks. I was nervous."

"I couldn't tell."

Jo laughed. "I was."

There was a brief silence.

Then Ananya looked at the guitar hanging from his shoulder.

"You really like music, don't you?"

Jo nodded.

"Yeah. A lot."

"I could tell."

She smiled once more before her friends called her from across the corridor.

"I'll see you around."

"Yeah. See you."

She walked away.

Jo watched her for a moment before turning back toward his friends.

Daniel was already standing there with the biggest grin on his face.

"Don't say it."

"I wasn't going to."

"You were."

"I definitely was."

Jo laughed.

Maybe this was what falling in love felt like.

At sixteen, he didn't know the difference yet.

For the next few weeks, Jo and Ananya remained exactly what they had always been—two students who happened to know each other.

There were no promises.

No dramatic confessions.

Just small conversations that slowly became familiar.

Sometimes she would ask about his music.

Sometimes he would help her with a difficult question in class.

Once, she left a chocolate on his desk after his performance.

He spent the entire day pretending it wasn't a big deal.

His friends knew better.

But somewhere along the way, Jo began to understand something.

Not every person who enters your life is meant to stay.

Some people simply arrive at the right moment, leave behind a few beautiful memories, and quietly become part of the story that shapes you.

He didn't know it then.

For Jo, this wasn't the beginning of forever.

It was simply his first lesson in love.

The school year moved on.

Exams arrived, disappeared, and were replaced by sports days, class trips, celebrations and the countless little moments that made those years feel endless while they were happening.

Jo and Ananya slowly became part of the same circle of familiar faces.

They talked.

They laughed.

Sometimes they sat together during lunch.

But nothing ever became what Jo had imagined it might.

There was no confession.

No grand moment.

No promise that they would stay together.

And strangely, Jo was okay with that.

One afternoon, while the four friends sat beneath their usual rain tree, Daniel asked, "So... what happened to your great love story?"

Jo smiled.

"I think it's still being written."

Arjun laughed.

"Very poetic."

Jo looked up at the branches above them.

Maybe he was right.

Maybe love wasn't supposed to happen just because you wanted it to.

Maybe some things simply needed time.

He just didn't know how much time he would need.

The years that followed taught Jo something he hadn't expected.

A crush could make your heart race.

A song could make you believe you had found something special.

But sometimes, feelings simply faded.

Ananya eventually became a good friend, then a familiar face, and finally a memory he would look back on with a smile.

There was no heartbreak.

No bitterness.

Just life moving forward.

By the time their final school year arrived, Jo had stopped searching for signs that love was waiting around every corner.

He still dreamed about it, of course.

He still imagined the day he would meet someone who felt like home.

But now, he understood that wanting something and finding it were two very different things.

And before he could find out where love was waiting for him...

there was another chapter of his life waiting first.

Bengaluru.

The last day of school arrived before Jo was ready for it.

The corridors that had once felt endless suddenly seemed smaller. The classrooms looked different without the noise of ordinary lessons, and the rain tree beneath which they had spent countless afternoons stood quietly in the summer heat.

Everyone was busy signing shirts, taking photographs and promising to stay in touch.

"We'll meet every weekend," Daniel announced.

"Obviously," Arjun agreed.

Kiran smiled.

"You'll forget by next month."

"We will not."

They all laughed.

Jo stood a little away from them, looking around the campus.

There was something strange about knowing that tomorrow, he wouldn't have to come back here.

No more morning assemblies.

No more rushing between classes.

No more waiting for the lunch bell.

He had spent years wanting to leave school.

Now that the moment had arrived...

he wasn't sure he wanted to go.

He looked at his friends and smiled.

Some chapters end quietly.

But the memories they leave behind never really do.

CHAPTER SIX

BENGALURU

That evening, Jo came home with a bag full of memories.

Photographs.

Signed shirts.

A few old notebooks he would probably never open again.

And a guitar pick someone had slipped into his pocket as a farewell gift.

He placed everything on his bed and sat beside it.

His room looked exactly the same.

The guitar was still resting in the corner.

For a moment, he thought about how much had changed since the first time he had picked it up.

He had performed on stage.

Made friends.

Had his first crush.

Learned what it felt like to admire someone and slowly let that feeling become a memory.

But one question remained.

He still hadn't found the love he had always imagined.

His phone buzzed.

Arjun: Tomorrow. New chapter.

Jo smiled.

He typed back.

Jo: New city.

A second message arrived.

Daniel: New girls.

Jo laughed.

Then he looked at the guitar.

Maybe Bengaluru would be different.

Maybe this time...

he would finally find what he had been searching for.

Bengaluru welcomed Jo with rain.

Not the gentle kind he was used to back home, but a sudden downpour that seemed to appear without warning and disappear just as quickly.

He stood outside the railway station with two bags beside him, watching cars, buses and bikes move through the wet streets.

Everything felt unfamiliar.

The language.

The roads.

The crowds.

Even the air felt different.

His father called to check if he had reached safely.

"Yes, I'm here."

"Did you find your place?"

Jo looked at the address saved on his phone.

"Almost."

"Take care."

"I will."

The call ended.

Jo picked up his bags and looked toward the road ahead.

For the first time, there was no school timetable waiting for him.

No familiar classroom.

No rain tree.

No friends just a few steps away.

Only a new city...

and an entirely unwritten chapter.

The apartment was on the third floor of a building that looked like it had been painted several times and cleaned only once.

Jo stood outside the door, checking the number on his phone for the third time.

"Please tell me this is the right place."

The door opened before he could knock again.

A boy about his age looked at him.

"You Jo?"

"Yeah."

"Come in, bro."

Jo stepped inside.

The apartment was smaller than the photographs had suggested.

A three-bedroom flat.

Six people.

Two mattresses already occupied the living room.

Shoes near the entrance.

Clothes hanging from chairs.

A half-empty packet of chips on the dining table.

And somewhere in the background, someone was arguing about who had finished the milk.

Jo smiled.

So this was Bengaluru.

He put his bags down and looked around.

It wasn't home.

Not yet.

But perhaps home didn't always begin that way.

Sometimes...

it began with six strangers sharing a three-bedroom apartment and figuring out how to survive together.

By evening, Jo had met all five of his roommates.

There was Aravind, who seemed permanently attached to his headphones; Sameer, who could turn any conversation into a debate; and Rahul, who had already claimed half the refrigerator as his personal property.

The other two were more interested in welcoming Jo with questions.

"Do you cook?"

"A little."

"Good. We need someone who can cook."

Jo laughed.

"I said a little."

"That's enough."

Someone from the kitchen shouted, "Who wants coffee?"

Three people answered at once.

Jo shook his head, smiling.

Within an hour, the apartment no longer felt quite as unfamiliar.

It was noisy, messy and completely different from home.

But there was something comforting about it.

Maybe college life wasn't going to be so bad after all.

That night, Jo unpacked his guitar and placed it beside his mattress.

One of his roommates looked over.

"You play?"

Jo smiled.

"Yeah."

"Sing too?"

"Sometimes."

The room went quiet for a second.

Then someone grinned.

"Bro, you're definitely performing at the next apartment party."

Jo laughed.

"Let's survive tomorrow first."

The next morning, Jo woke up to voices arguing in the kitchen.

"Who finished my bread?"

"I didn't!"

"Then who did?"

Jo opened his eyes and stared at the ceiling.

For a moment, he forgot where he was.

Then he remembered.

Bengaluru.

New apartment.

New roommates.

New life.

A smile appeared on his face.

Back home, mornings had been quiet.

Here, apparently, they came with arguments.

He grabbed his towel and headed toward the bathroom.

"Jo! You're going to be late!"

He froze.

"Late for what?"

"College!"

Jo looked at the clock.

His eyes widened.

"Oh, no."

Within seconds, the apartment turned into chaos.

Jo grabbed his bag, rushed toward the door, and barely managed to put his shoes on properly.

As he stepped outside, he laughed.

His new life had officially begun.

By the time Jo reached the college gates, the morning rush was already in full swing.

Students crossed the campus in every direction, some hurrying to class, others standing in groups and trying to figure out where they were supposed to go.

Jo checked his timetable again.

Wrong building.

He sighed.

"Great start."

His phone buzzed.

Arjun: Reached?

Jo smiled and typed back.

Jo: Lost.

The reply came almost immediately.

Arjun: Welcome to college.

Jo put his phone away and looked around.

The campus was bigger than anything he had known before.

New faces.

New places.

New stories waiting to happen.

He adjusted his backpack and started walking.

For the first time, Jo wasn't looking for a classroom.

He was looking for where he belonged.

CHAPTER SEVEN

A LIFE OF HIS OWN

College slowly stopped feeling like a place Jo had to figure out.

The corridors became familiar. He began recognizing faces, remembering classrooms, and learning which canteen served decent food and which one was best avoided.

His roommates became friends rather than strangers.

Some evenings were spent arguing over football. Others disappeared into conversations that somehow lasted until midnight.

Jo began to enjoy the freedom of it all.

There were no teachers asking why he was late.

No one checking whether his homework was complete.

For the first time, most of his choices were his own.

And with that freedom came something he hadn't expected.

Responsibility.

He was growing up.

Slowly.

Quietly.

Without even realizing it.

The freedom of college also meant discovering parts of himself he had never really noticed before.

Jo started spending more time with his guitar again.

Some evenings, he would sit on the apartment balcony after dinner, playing quietly while the city moved below him.

Cars passed.

People talked.

Rain came and went.

Bengaluru was always awake.

One night, Sameer stepped onto the balcony and leaned against the railing.

"You ever get tired of playing that thing?"

Jo smiled.

"Not really."

"What do you think about while you play?"

Jo looked down at the guitar.

He thought for a moment.

"Usually nothing."

Sameer laughed.

"That's impossible."

"Maybe that's why I like it."

For a while, neither of them spoke.

The city continued making noise below.

Jo simply played.

And somehow, the noise didn't bother him anymore.

College began to settle into a rhythm.

Lectures in the morning. Assignments in the afternoon. Long conversations with his roommates at night.

Some days were exhausting.

Others were unexpectedly fun.

Jo joined a small music group on campus and started performing at informal student gatherings whenever he got the chance.

He wasn't chasing applause anymore.

He simply enjoyed playing.

One evening, after a small performance, a classmate walked up to him.

"You play really well."

Jo smiled.

"Thank you."

"You should perform at the college fest."

Jo laughed.

"Maybe."

As she walked away, Daniel's voice came back to him from years ago.

You're going to become famous.

Jo smiled to himself.

Maybe Daniel had been right about one thing.

Some dreams didn't disappear.

They simply changed shape as you grew.

As the months passed, Jo became more comfortable in the city.

He learned which roads flooded after heavy rain, which café stayed open late, and which bus route was worth avoiding during rush hour.

More importantly, he began building a life that felt like his own.

He made new friends.

He discovered new music.

He learned to manage his studies, his responsibilities, and the occasional chaos of apartment life.

Sometimes, late at night, he would lie awake and think about home.

He missed his parents.

He missed the rain tree.

He even missed the familiar noise of school.

But he never regretted leaving.

Bengaluru had taught him something simple:

Growing up wasn't about leaving your old life behind.

It was about carrying the best parts of it with you while becoming someone new.

CHAPTER EIGHT

THE SILENT LOVE

By his second year of college, Jo had settled comfortably into Bengaluru.

College no longer felt unfamiliar. His roommates had become family, his friends had become part of his everyday routine, and most days followed a rhythm of classes, assignments, music and whatever plans his friends managed to create at the last minute.

That Saturday was no different.

"We're going out today," Aravind announced over breakfast.

Jo looked up from his phone.

"Where?"

"Somewhere."

"That's not a place."

"It is if we don't tell you."

Jo laughed.

By noon, the four of them were already out, arguing about where to eat, making jokes about each other and taking photographs they would probably forget about in a week.

For once, Jo wasn't thinking about love.

He wasn't searching for anyone.

He was simply enjoying an ordinary day with his friends.

He had no idea that, before the day was over, someone was going to quite literally run into his life

The afternoon disappeared faster than they expected.

By the time Jo and his friends returned to campus, they were already arguing about dinner.

"I'm telling you, we should order pizza," Aravind said.

"We had pizza yesterday," Jo replied.

"And?"

"And we have functioning taste buds."

Sameer laughed.

"You say that now. Wait until you're hungry."

They reached the main building, still arguing.

Jo suddenly remembered that he had forgotten to collect a form from the department office.

"You guys go ahead. I'll catch up."

He turned toward the staircase.

The building was unusually crowded. Students were rushing between floors, conversations echoing through the corridor.

Jo checked his phone.

He was already late.

"Perfect."

He took the stairs two at a time.

He reached the next landing, turned the corner without looking ahead—

And collided with someone.

Hard.

For a moment, everything stopped.

Jo's bag slipped from his shoulder, and a notebook fell to the floor.

The girl he had collided with stumbled back.

Jo froze.

Somewhere inside his head, an imaginary movie soundtrack began playing.

Slow motion.

Perfect sunlight.

Her hair moving in the breeze.

This is it.

Then,

"HELLO!"

The fantasy disappeared.

A girl standing beside her glared at him.

"Don't you have eyes?"

"I'm sorry. I didn't see her."

"Obviously."

Jo looked at the girl.

She simply picked up her notebook.

She hadn't said a word.

Jo frowned.

"Why are you shouting? She's not even saying anything."

Her friend stared at him.

Jo immediately regretted saying it.

"Okay... sorry. Again."

They walked away.

Jo stood there, completely confused.

Jo found his friends near the canteen a few minutes later.

Aravind looked at him.

"What happened?"

"Nothing."

"You look confused."

Jo dropped into the chair beside them.

"I just crashed into someone."

Sameer raised an eyebrow.

"Literally?"

"Literally."

They burst out laughing.

"It wasn't funny."

"It definitely was."

Jo shook his head.

"I don't even know who she is."

Aravind grinned.

"Was she pretty?"

Jo paused.

"I don't know."

"How do you not know?"

"I was too busy falling."

They laughed again.

Jo tried to ignore them.

But later that night, the incident kept replaying in his mind.

He didn't know her name.

He didn't know her class.

Yet somehow, he had a feeling he hadn't seen the last of her.

The next few days passed normally.

Jo went to class, attended meetings, practised with his music group, and spent his evenings with his roommates.

The staircase incident should have been forgotten.

But then, during lunch, Aravind suddenly pointed across the courtyard.

"Bro."

Jo looked up.

"That's her."

Jo followed his gaze.

The same girl.

She was standing with a few classmates near the library.

Jo recognized her immediately.

Then he noticed something else.

She was communicating with her friend using her hands.

Jo watched quietly.

He didn't understand what they were saying.

Aravind looked at him.

"That's the girl you crashed into?"

Jo nodded.

For the first time, he wondered if there had been more to that strange encounter than he had realized.

Jo kept watching for a moment.

Then he looked away.

"She's deaf," he said quietly.

Aravind nodded.

Jo felt something sink in his chest.

The girl hadn't ignored him that day.

She hadn't been rude.

She simply hadn't heard him.

And suddenly, he remembered what he had said.

"Why are you shouting? She's not even saying anything."

Jo covered his face with his hand.

"Oh no."

Aravind laughed.

"What?"

"I made it worse."

"How?"

"I thought she was ignoring me."

Aravind looked at him.

"So?"

Jo sighed.

"Now I feel terrible."

For the first time since the accident, Jo wasn't embarrassed.

He was genuinely sorry.

And he knew he had to apologize.

That evening, Jo brought the situation up with his roommates.

"I need to apologize to her."

Sameer looked up from his phone.

"Then apologize."

"I know. But how?"

Aravind shrugged.

"Flowers."

"No."

"Chocolate."

"Why would I give her chocolate?"

"Peace offering."

Jo shook his head.

Rahul looked over from the kitchen.

"Just go and say sorry."

Jo sighed.

"That's what I'm trying to figure out."

They all stared at him.

Then Sameer smiled.

"Bro, you're overthinking a simple apology."

Jo looked at them.

"Maybe."

For once, he decided not to listen to everyone's suggestions.

He would just find her...

and say sorry.

The next afternoon, Jo saw her near the library.

For a moment, he almost walked past.

Then he stopped.

"Hey."

She looked at him.

Jo pointed toward himself, then awkwardly tried to get her attention without startling her.

"I'm sorry about the other day."

She watched him for a moment.

Jo continued.

"I was rushing down the stairs. I wasn't looking where I was going."

A small smile appeared on her face.

She nodded.

Jo smiled back.

He wasn't sure if she had completely understood his apology.

But somehow, he felt better for saying it.

As he walked away, he realized something.

He still didn't know her name.

But for the first time, he wanted to.

That evening, Jo told his roommates what had happened.

"So you apologized?" Aravind asked.

"Yeah."

"And?"

"She smiled."

The room went quiet.

Sameer slowly looked at him.

"Bro."

"What?"

"You're smiling."

Jo immediately stopped.

"I'm not."

"You definitely are."

Rahul laughed from the kitchen.

"He's gone."

Jo threw a cushion at him.

"Can all of you stop?"

They laughed.

Jo smiled again despite himself.

He still didn't know her name.

He didn't know where this would lead.

For now, he was simply glad that one awkward mistake had been forgiven.

He had no idea that this small apology would become the beginning of something much bigger

A few days later, Jo finally learned her name.

He was leaving the music room when he heard someone call out to her.

"Hey, Mouna!"

Jo looked up.

Mouna.

He repeated the name silently.

It suited her somehow.

That evening, an announcement appeared on the college notice board.

OPEN MIC — FRIDAY

Jo smiled.

Music was always an easy excuse to perform.

His friends immediately started planning what he should sing.

"Something romantic," Aravind suggested.

"Absolutely not."

"Then something emotional."

Jo laughed.

He looked at the poster again.

For some reason, he wondered if Mouna would be there.

He didn't know why.

He just hoped she would.

Friday arrived quickly.

The campus was unusually lively that evening. Students filled the open-air stage, talking, laughing and waiting for the performances to begin.

Jo stood backstage with his guitar.

"You nervous?" Aravind asked.

"A little."

"You'll be fine."

Jo nodded and looked toward the crowd.

Then he saw her.

Mouna was sitting near the front with her friends.

She noticed him too.

For a second, they simply looked at each other.

Jo smiled.

She smiled back.

His nervousness disappeared.

When his name was announced, Jo walked onto the stage, adjusted the microphone and looked once more toward her.

Then he began to play.

"Mannippaya... from vinnaihaandi varuvaaya"("Sharminda Hoon - Ek Deewana Tha")

The first few notes filled the evening air.

Jo stopped thinking about the crowd.

He stopped thinking about whether he was playing well.

He simply let the music take over.

When the final note faded, the audience applauded.

Jo looked toward Mouna.

She was smiling.

Not the polite smile people gave after a performance.

A real one.

Jo smiled back.

As he stepped off the stage, Aravind immediately grabbed his shoulder.

"Bro."

"What?"

"That song."

Jo laughed.

"What about it?"

"Nothing."

Aravind gave him a knowing look.

Jo shook his head.

"Don't start."

But for once, he didn't mind the teasing.

Because somewhere in the crowd, Mouna was still smiling

After the performance, Jo stepped away from the crowd to put his guitar back.

A few minutes later, he noticed Mouna standing nearby.

She was waiting for her friends.

Jo hesitated.

Then she looked at him and smiled.

He smiled back.

She pointed toward the stage and gave him a small thumbs-up.

Jo laughed.

"Thank you."

She made a simple gesture with her hands.

Jo didn't understand it.

He looked at her, slightly embarrassed.

"I... don't know what that means."

Mouna laughed.

Then she repeated the gesture more slowly.

Jo tried to copy it.

This time, she smiled wider.

For the first time, Jo wasn't trying to find the right words.

He was simply trying to understand her

Mouna pointed toward the empty chairs near the side of the stage.

Jo understood.

They sat down together.

For a few seconds, neither of them knew what to do.

Then Jo smiled.

"I'm Jo."

Mouna smiled too.

She opened her bag and pulled out a small diary.

Jo watched as she wrote something on the page.

She turned it toward him.

Mouna.

Jo smiled.

"I know."

She looked surprised.

"I heard someone call your name."

Mouna laughed quietly.

Then she wrote:

You remembered?

Jo nodded.

"Of course."

She smiled.

And somehow, that little diary made the silence between them feel much smaller

Jo pointed at the diary.

"You carry that everywhere?"

Mouna nodded.

She wrote:

Mostly.

Jo smiled.

"So this is how you talk?"

She thought for a moment before writing:

Sometimes.

Then she handed him the pen.

Jo looked at the blank page.

"What am I supposed to write?"

Mouna shrugged.

He thought for a moment.

Then wrote:

Sorry. Again.

Mouna looked at him and smiled.

She took the pen back.

Under his words, she wrote:

Already forgiven.

Jo laughed.

For the first time, he realized something.

They didn't need a perfect conversation.

They just needed a way to begin.

After that evening, the diary slowly became part of their conversations.

Sometimes Mouna would leave a question for Jo.

Sometimes Jo would write something ridiculous just to make her laugh.

Once, he opened the diary and found:

You talk too much.

Jo looked at her.

"I haven't even said anything."

She smiled and pointed at the page.

He laughed.

"Okay. Fair."

Their conversations were different from everyone else's.

Slower.

Quieter.

But somehow, Jo began looking forward to them.

The diary wasn't just a way for them to communicate anymore.

It was becoming theirs.

A few days later, Jo stopped outside a small shop near campus.

He remembered something Aravind had said.

"Flowers. Chocolate. Something."

Jo laughed at the memory.

Then he looked through the glass.

A small chocolate bar caught his attention.

He picked it up.

For a moment, he wondered if it was too much.

Then he remembered Mouna's diary.

Already forgiven.

Jo smiled.

Maybe this wasn't about impressing her.

Maybe he simply wanted to say thank you.

So he bought it.

And the next day, he carried it to college.

He just had to find the courage to give it to her

The next morning, Jo finally saw Mouna near the library.

He walked toward her, the chocolate hidden behind his back.

Mouna noticed him and smiled.

Jo suddenly felt nervous.

"Hey."

She nodded.

He held out the chocolate.

"For you."

Mouna looked at it, then at him.

She seemed surprised.

Jo quickly added, "Just... a thank you."

She took it.

Then she opened her diary and wrote something.

She turned the page toward him.

For what?

Jo smiled.

"For forgiving me."

Mouna looked at him for a moment.

Then she wrote:

You really don't have to keep apologizing.

Jo laughed.

"Okay. I'll try."

She smiled.

And for some reason, that tiny chocolate felt like the beginning of something neither of them had words for yet.

After that, the chocolate became a small joke between them.

The next time Jo saw Mouna, she held up the empty wrapper from her bag.

He laughed.

"You actually finished it?"

She nodded proudly.

Then she opened her diary and wrote:

It was good.

Jo smiled.

"I'll remember that."

She quickly wrote another line.

Don't make this a habit.

Jo laughed.

"No promises."

Mouna shook her head, smiling.

Their friendship was beginning in the strangest way.

A staircase accident.

An awkward apology.

A song.

A little diary.

And now, a chocolate.

None of it felt like a love story.

Not yet.

It simply felt like two people slowly finding a way to understand each other

As the weeks passed, Jo started learning more than just a few signs.

He learned how Mouna liked her coffee.

Which songs made her smile.

How she rolled her eyes whenever he made a terrible joke.

And, most importantly, he learned not to assume that silence meant there was nothing to say.

One afternoon, Jo tried signing a sentence he had practised the night before.

Mouna stared at him.

Then she burst out laughing.

"What?"

She quickly opened her diary.

You just said, "I like potatoes."

Jo stared at her.

"I was trying to say I like music."

Mouna laughed even harder.

Jo shook his head.

"Okay. I'm never signing again."

She smiled and wrote:

Try again tomorrow.

Jo smiled.

Maybe he would.

Jo began looking forward to the little moments they shared.

Sometimes they would sit together after class.

Sometimes Mouna would leave a message in her diary for him to find later.

Once, she wrote:

Why do you always carry your guitar?

Jo smiled and wrote underneath:

Because it listens without interrupting.

Mouna read it and looked at him.

Then she wrote:

Maybe that's why I like it.

Jo didn't know what to say.

So he simply smiled.

For the first time, he began to understand that getting close to someone wasn't always about having long conversations.

Sometimes it was about noticing the little things.

And Jo was beginning to notice everything about her

Their friendship became part of Jo's routine.

He would look for Mouna between classes without even realizing he was doing it.

Sometimes she would wave from across the corridor.

Sometimes she would simply hold up the diary, already smiling.

One afternoon, she wrote:

You are always late.

Jo took the pen.

You are always early.

She thought for a moment and wrote:

Maybe that's why we keep meeting.

Jo looked at the sentence for a few seconds.

Then he smiled.

Maybe she was joking.

Maybe she wasn't.

For now, Jo didn't ask.

He was beginning to enjoy the uncertainty.

One evening, Jo was sitting with his roommates when Aravind noticed the diary on the table.

"What's that?"

"Nothing."

Aravind picked it up.

Jo immediately grabbed it back.

"Hey!"

The room went silent.

Sameer raised an eyebrow.

"Interesting."

Jo sighed.

"It's Mouna's."

Aravind grinned.

"So there is a Mouna."

Jo threw a cushion at him.

"She's just a friend."

"Of course."

Jo smiled despite himself.

He didn't know when it had happened.

Somewhere between the diary pages, shared smiles and badly signed sentences, Mouna had become part of his everyday life.

And maybe that was how it started.

Not with a confession.

Not with fireworks.

Just with two people choosing to keep talking.

One evening, Jo and Mouna stayed back after class.

The campus was quieter than usual.

They sat beneath a tree, sharing the diary between them.

Mouna wrote:

What did you want to become when you were younger?

Jo smiled.

"Musician."

She raised an eyebrow.

He laughed.

"Okay, maybe not professionally. I just wanted to keep playing."

She wrote:

And now?

Jo looked at the question for a moment.

"I don't know."

Mouna waited.

Jo smiled.

"Maybe I'm still figuring it out."

She nodded and wrote:

Me too.

For a while, neither of them wrote anything.

They simply sat there.

And somehow, Jo felt completely comfortable with the silence.

He didn't know it yet.

But this was no longer just friendship

Jo didn't tell his friends what he was feeling.

He wasn't even sure himself.

He only knew that Mouna had somehow become part of his day.

If she wasn't around, he noticed.

If she smiled, his mood changed.

If she wrote something in the diary, he found himself reading it twice.

One evening, he opened the diary and found a question waiting for him.

Why are you always so curious about me?

Jo stared at the page.

He smiled and picked up the pen.

For once, he didn't try to make a joke.

He wrote:

I don't know. I just like knowing you.

Mouna read it quietly.

Then she closed the diary.

And smiled.

The next morning, Mouna handed the diary to Jo before class.

He opened it.

There was only one line.

You make me laugh.

Jo looked up at her.

She was already smiling.

He wrote underneath:

That's a dangerous thing to tell me.

Mouna took the diary back and added:

I know.

Jo laughed.

For a moment, he simply watched her.

Something about the way she smiled made the entire room feel quieter.

He had spent years wondering what love would feel like.

Now, for the first time, he wasn't trying to find an answer.

He was simply beginning to feel it.

The following week, Jo found himself thinking about Mouna more than usual.

Not constantly.

Just in little moments.

A song would remind him of her.

A joke would make him wonder how she would react.

Even the diary had started feeling strangely important.

Then, on Sunday morning, Jo walked into church and stopped.

Mouna was there.

She was sitting with her family a few rows ahead.

For a moment, Jo simply stared.

He hadn't expected to see her there.

During the service, their eyes met once.

She smiled.

Jo smiled back.

It was a small moment.

But somehow, seeing her there made him feel like he had discovered another little piece of her.

And he wanted to know more.

After the service, Jo waited outside with his friends.

A few minutes later, he noticed Mouna walking toward the church entrance.

She saw him and smiled.

Jo smiled back.

Then she opened her diary.

You come here every Sunday?

Jo nodded.

"Usually."

She wrote:

Me too.

Jo laughed softly.

"So we were coming to the same church all this time?"

Mouna smiled and nodded.

They stood there for a moment, neither of them knowing what to say next.

Then Jo pointed toward the small café across the road.

"Coffee?"

Mouna smiled.

She wrote:

Only if you're paying.

Jo laughed.

"Deal."

They walked out together.

It was their first Sunday conversation.

And somehow, it felt different.

The café was small and almost empty.

Jo ordered two coffees while Mouna found a table near the window.

She opened her diary.

You always play music on Sundays?

"Not always."

Jo took the pen.

You always carry this diary?

Mouna nodded.

Almost.

He smiled.

"Why?"

She thought for a moment before writing.

Some things are easier to write.

Jo read the sentence twice.

Then he nodded.

"Yeah. I understand."

They sat quietly for a while.

There was no pressure to keep talking.

No awkwardness.

Just two people slowly becoming comfortable with each other.

When they finally left, Jo realized something.

He had spent an entire afternoon with Mouna without once wishing for the silence to end.

After that Sunday, their routine changed without either of them deciding it should.

They still met between classes.

They still exchanged pages in the diary.

But now, Sundays belonged to them too.

Sometimes they stayed after Mass and walked around the church grounds.

Sometimes they stopped for coffee.

Sometimes they simply sat together and watched people come and go.

One Sunday, Mouna wrote:

You are quieter here.

Jo smiled.

"Maybe this place makes me think."

She looked at him.

He added, "About life. About everything."

Mouna wrote:

Good thoughts?

Jo thought for a moment.

Then smiled.

"Mostly."

She laughed.

And somehow, the quietest days were becoming his favourite ones.

Over time, Jo started noticing how naturally Mouna had become part of his life.

She was there between classes.

In the pages of her diary.

At Sunday coffee.

Sometimes, they didn't even need to talk.

One afternoon, Mouna handed him the diary.

Jo opened it.

What makes you happy?

He thought for a moment.

Then he wrote:

Music. My friends. My family.

He paused.

Then added:

And lately... Sundays.

Mouna read the answer.

She looked at him with a small smile.

Then she closed the diary without writing anything.

Jo smiled.

He didn't need her to.

He already knew.

As their friendship grew, Jo began noticing the little things.

Mouna always carried two pens because she was convinced one would stop working.

She hated overly sweet coffee.

She laughed whenever Jo tried to use a new sign and got it completely wrong.

And whenever something mattered, she wrote it down instead of leaving it unsaid.

One evening, Jo found a new page waiting in the diary.

What are you afraid of?

He stared at the question.

Then he wrote:

Losing people I love.

Mouna read it quietly.

After a moment, she wrote:

Then don't take them for granted.

Jo looked at her.

For once, he had no clever reply.

He simply nodded.

That sentence stayed with him long after they went home

The question stayed with Jo for a while.

Maybe because he had spent so much of his life believing that love was something you found.

Now, he was beginning to understand that it was also something you chose.

You chose to listen.

To stay.

To learn.

To make room for another person in your life.

That evening, Jo opened the diary before giving it back to Mouna.

He wrote:

I think I'm starting to understand.

Mouna read it.

She looked at him, curious.

Understand what?

Jo smiled.

He closed the diary.

"Maybe I'll tell you later."

Mouna shook her head, laughing.

But as they walked home, Jo knew one thing for certain.

Whatever this was becoming...

he didn't want to rush it.

The next Sunday, Jo arrived at church a little earlier than usual.

He wasn't sure why.

Maybe he simply wanted a few quiet minutes before the service.

Or maybe he was hoping to see someone.

He sat in his usual place and looked around.

A few minutes later, Mouna walked in.

She noticed him immediately.

A smile appeared on her face.

Jo smiled back.

After the service, she handed him the diary.

There was only one line.

You came early today.

Jo laughed.

"I could say the same about you."

She wrote:

I always come early.

Jo looked at her.

"Then I guess I'm the one who changed."

Mouna smiled.

She didn't write anything else.

She didn't need to.

Jo already knew why he had come early.

That evening, Jo was sitting on the apartment balcony with his guitar when Aravind joined him.

"You've been smiling a lot lately."

Jo looked at him.

"Have I?"

"Yes."

Jo looked back at the city.

"Maybe I'm just happy."

Aravind smiled.

"Is there a reason?"

Jo didn't answer immediately.

Then he picked up his guitar.

"Maybe."

Aravind laughed.

"That's all I'm getting?"

"That's all."

But after Aravind left, Jo sat quietly for a while.

He thought about Mouna.

The diary.

Their Sundays.

The little chocolate wrapper she had kept.

And the way she always smiled when he tried to sign something correctly.

Maybe Jo already knew what was happening.

He just wasn't ready to say it out loud.

The next few weeks passed quietly.

Jo and Mouna grew closer without ever announcing that they were becoming something more.

Their conversations lasted longer.

Their walks became slower.

The diary filled with little jokes, questions and thoughts neither of them said aloud.

One evening, Mouna wrote:

Do you believe people meet for a reason?

Jo looked at her.

"I used to."

She waited.

"I think I still do."

Mouna smiled and wrote:

Why?

Jo took the pen.

He thought about the staircase.

The apology.

The first song.

The chocolate.

The Sundays.

Then he wrote:

Because some meetings are too strange to be accidents.

Mouna read it quietly.

This time, she didn't smile.

She simply looked at him for a long moment.

And somehow, Jo understood.

After that evening, something between them felt different.

Nothing had changed.

And yet, everything had.

Jo became more careful with the things he said.

Mouna seemed to notice every little hesitation.

One Sunday, after Mass, they sat beneath the old tree near the church.

Mouna opened the diary and wrote:

You think too much.

Jo smiled.

"Maybe."

She wrote again:

About me?

Jo looked at her.

For once, he didn't joke.

"Sometimes."

Mouna held his gaze for a moment.

Then she closed the diary.

Neither of them said anything.

But as they sat there together, Jo realized something he had been slowly avoiding.

He wasn't simply getting to know Mouna anymore.

He was falling for her.

Jo didn't tell anyone.

Not his roommates.

Not his friends.

Not even Mouna.

For now, he kept the feeling quietly to himself.

He continued showing up.

He continued learning her signs.

He continued writing in the diary.

And every Sunday, he found himself sitting beside her a little longer.

One evening, Mouna handed him the diary.

There was a question waiting for him.

What do you want most?

Jo looked at the words for a long time.

Years ago, he would have written:

To find true love.

But this time, he wrote something different.

To find someone I can be myself with.

Mouna read it.

Then she slowly wrote:

Maybe you already did.

Jo looked up.

She was smiling.

And for once, he had nothing to say

For the rest of the evening, Jo kept thinking about what Mouna had written.

Maybe you already did.

He replayed the sentence again and again.

Was she talking about him?

Was she simply being kind?

He didn't know.

And strangely, he didn't want to ask.

Some moments felt better when you allowed them to remain unfinished.

The next morning, Jo opened the diary.

He found a new page.

Good morning.

Underneath it, he wrote:

Good morning.

Then, after a moment, he added:

You made me think a lot yesterday.

Mouna read it and smiled.

She wrote:

Good.

Jo laughed.

"That's all?"

She nodded.

For now, it was enough.

They were getting closer.

And neither of them needed to rush what was already becoming beautiful

The days continued to pass, and Jo slowly stopped wondering whether Mouna felt the same.

Not because he had an answer.

Because being around her had become enough.

One evening, they sat outside the library, sharing the diary between them.

Mouna wrote:

You are different now.

Jo smiled.

"Different how?"

She thought for a moment.

Quieter.

Jo laughed.

"That's your fault."

She smiled.

Then she wrote one more line.

Maybe that's not a bad thing.

Jo looked at her.

He thought about the boy he had once been—the boy who believed love would arrive like a movie scene.

He finally understood.

Sometimes love didn't arrive loudly.

Sometimes it simply sat beside you...

and waited for you to notice

One Sunday, after Mass, Mouna asked Jo to stay back for a while.

They sat on the steps outside the church.

She opened the diary and wrote:

What do you want your life to look like someday?

Jo smiled.

"I don't know."

She raised an eyebrow.

He laughed.

"Okay, fine. Music. A good life. People I love around me."

He paused.

"Peace."

Mouna read it carefully.

Then she wrote:

That sounds nice.

Jo looked at her.

"What about you?"

She thought for a moment before writing.

I want to be understood.

Jo became quiet.

He looked at her, then at the diary.

"I think everyone wants that."

Mouna smiled.

But Jo knew her answer meant something more.

And he wanted to understand.

From then on, Jo started paying closer attention.

Not just to what Mouna wrote, but to everything she left unsaid.

He noticed how her expression changed when she was excited.

How she became quiet when something bothered her.

How she always made sure everyone around her felt included.

One afternoon, Jo asked her through the diary:

What do you wish people understood about you?

Mouna thought for a long moment.

Then she wrote:

That being quiet doesn't mean I have nothing to say.

Jo read it twice.

Then he wrote:

I know.

Mouna looked at him.

He smiled.

I'm learning.

She closed the diary.

And for the first time, Jo understood that loving someone wasn't about speaking for them.

It was about taking the time to listen

That evening, Jo sat on the apartment balcony with his guitar.

He thought about everything that had changed.

The boy who once imagined love through movie scenes would have never imagined this.

There were no perfect introductions.

No dramatic confessions.

Just a staircase accident, an apology, a diary, a chocolate, and countless ordinary Sundays.

Jo smiled.

Maybe that was what made it real.

He picked up his guitar and began to play.

A message arrived on his phone.

Mouna: Are you playing?

Jo smiled.

Jo: How did you know?

Her reply came quickly.

Mouna: I know you.

Jo stared at those three words.

Then he looked at the guitar in his hands.

For the first time, they didn't feel like just words.

They felt like home.

The next Sunday, Mouna arrived at church carrying the same little diary.

Jo smiled when he saw it.

"Still carrying that everywhere?"

She nodded.

Then she opened it and wrote:

You still owe me a chocolate.

Jo stared at the page.

"I already gave you one."

She shook her head and wrote:

That was for forgiving you.

Jo laughed.

"So what is this one for?"

Mouna looked at him for a moment.

Then she wrote:

I don't know. You decide.

Jo smiled.

"That's dangerous."

She closed the diary.

For the rest of the morning, Jo kept wondering what he could possibly give her.

He didn't realize it yet, but the answer would become one of the smallest, and most meaningful, gestures of their story.

After Mass, Jo disappeared for a few minutes.

When he returned, he was hiding something behind his back.

Mouna looked at him curiously.

Jo smiled.

"Remember you said I could decide?"

She nodded.

He brought out a small chocolate and held it toward her.

Mouna looked at it, then at him.

She opened the diary.

Again?

Jo laughed.

"Apparently."

She took the chocolate and wrote:

Thank you.

Jo smiled.

"For what?"

Mouna looked at him for a moment.

Then she wrote:

For remembering.

Jo didn't know exactly what she meant.

But he liked the way it felt.

They walked out of the church together, the diary tucked safely between them.

Neither of them noticed how natural it had become.

By now, Jo's friends had noticed.

Not the diary.

Not the chocolates.

Definitely not the Sundays.

Just the way Jo smiled whenever Mouna's name appeared on his phone.

One evening, Aravind finally asked.

"So... are you going to tell us?"

"Tell you what?"

"Whatever is happening."

Jo smiled.

"Nothing is happening."

Sameer laughed.

"That's exactly what someone would say when something is happening."

Jo shook his head.

"She's my friend."

Aravind looked at him.

"Right."

Jo didn't argue.

Because somewhere inside, he knew they were probably right.

He just wasn't ready to give the feeling a name yet.

One evening, Mouna handed Jo the diary before they left campus.

He opened it while walking.

Do you believe in love?

Jo stopped.

The question took him back years.

To school.

To the rain tree.

To all the times he had imagined what finding the right person would feel like.

He looked at Mouna.

Then he wrote:

I think I do.

She waited.

Jo added:

But I think I understand it differently now.

Mouna read the page carefully.

Then she wrote:

How?

Jo smiled.

He didn't answer immediately.

Some things were easier to feel than explain.

And maybe, for once, he wanted to show her instead.

The next Sunday, Jo brought the diary back to Mouna.

There was already a sentence waiting for him.

You never answered my question.

Jo smiled.

"I know."

She looked at him expectantly.

He took the pen.

Maybe I will someday.

Mouna read it and shook her head.

Coward.

Jo laughed.

"Maybe."

She closed the diary and stood up.

As they walked toward the church entrance, Jo looked at her.

He had spent years imagining the moment when he would finally tell someone how he felt.

But now that the moment was getting closer, he wasn't afraid of saying it.

He was afraid of saying it too soon.

Because this wasn't a crush anymore.

This was something worth protecting.

For the next few days, Jo kept thinking about that conversation.

He knew what he wanted to say.

He just didn't know when to say it.

One evening, he opened the diary and found a question waiting for him.

Are you happy?

Jo smiled.

He took the pen.

Yes.

He paused.

Then added:

More than I expected.

Mouna read it quietly.

She didn't write anything back.

Instead, she simply looked at him and smiled.

Jo understood.

Sometimes, the answer didn't need another sentence.

For the first time, he wasn't searching for love anymore.

He knew where it was.

He just needed the courage to tell her.

Jo had made up his mind.

He wasn't going to wait for some perfect moment.

There would probably never be one.

That evening, he sat on the balcony with his guitar, thinking about everything that had brought him here.

The staircase.

The apology.

The diary.

The chocolates.

The Sundays.

And Mouna.

He smiled.

For years, Jo had imagined love as something loud enough to announce itself.

Now he understood that sometimes, the most important things happened quietly.

He picked up his phone and sent her a message.

Jo: Can I see you tomorrow?

A few minutes later, her reply arrived.

Mouna: Okay.

Jo put his phone down.

His heart was beating faster than it should.

Tomorrow, he would finally tell her.

The next morning, Jo reached the church earlier than usual.

He sat quietly for a few minutes, trying to calm himself.

He had imagined this moment so many times.

But now that it was actually here, none of those imagined words seemed right.

Mouna arrived a little later.

She saw him and smiled.

Jo stood up.

For a moment, neither of them moved.

Then Mouna opened the diary.

She wrote:

You look nervous.

Jo laughed softly.

"Very."

She smiled.

Then she handed him the pen.

Jo looked at the blank page.

This time, he knew exactly what he wanted to write.

He took a breath.

And began.

Jo slowly wrote on the page.

I don't know when it happened.

Mouna watched him carefully.

He continued.

Maybe it was somewhere between the first apology and all the Sundays after.

He paused.

Then wrote:

But somewhere along the way, you became the person I look for.

Mouna read the words quietly.

Jo looked at her.

"I've spent a long time wondering what love would feel like."

He smiled nervously.

"I think I'm finally starting to understand."

Mouna didn't write anything.

She simply held the diary against her chest.

And for a moment, the silence between them said everything Jo had been trying to put into words.

Mouna slowly opened the diary again.

For a moment, Jo wondered if he had said too much.

Then she picked up the pen.

She wrote:

I was wondering when you would finally say it.

Jo looked at her.

"You knew?"

She smiled and nodded.

He laughed nervously.

"That makes one of us."

Mouna turned the page and wrote:

You took a long time.

Jo smiled.

"Sorry."

She shook her head.

Then she wrote one final line.

Don't be.

Jo looked at the words.

And for the first time, he didn't need another answer.

They sat there quietly, side by side.

Not quite knowing what came next.

But knowing they wanted to find out together.

After that day, nothing changed immediately.

They didn't suddenly become a perfect couple.

They were still Jo and Mouna.

They still argued over small things.

She still laughed whenever he made mistakes with sign language.

He still pretended not to care when she teased him.

But something had shifted.

There was no more guessing.

No more wondering.

They both knew.

One evening, Jo opened the diary and found a single sentence waiting for him.

So... what are we now?

Jo smiled.

He took the pen.

I don't know.

Then he added:

But I like where we are.

Mouna read it and smiled.

For now, that was enough.

The days after their conversation felt lighter.

There was no dramatic change between them.

They simply became more comfortable.

Mouna no longer hesitated before reaching for the diary.

Jo no longer worried about saying the wrong thing.

Sometimes they talked for hours.

Sometimes they sat together without saying much at all.

And slowly, Jo began learning her world.

Not just the signs.

Not just the words she wrote.

But the little things that made her who she was.

One evening, Mouna wrote:

You are still learning.

Jo smiled.

"Yeah."

She added:

Good.

Jo looked at her.

"Why?"

Mouna closed the diary.

And smiled.

Because she knew he was finally beginning to understand.

Their relationship slowly found its own rhythm.

There were no rules.

No grand announcements.

Just little things.

Jo waiting for Mouna after class.

Mouna saving him a seat.

Their diary moving between them almost every day.

And Sundays at church becoming something they both looked forward to.

One afternoon, Jo forgot his diary at home.

Mouna noticed immediately.

She raised an eyebrow.

Jo laughed.

"I forgot it."

She crossed her arms.

"So what now?"

Jo smiled.

"We talk."

Mouna laughed.

And for the first time, they spent the entire afternoon without writing a single word

After that day, Jo realized something.

The diary had brought them together.

But it wasn't the only way they understood each other anymore.

Mouna could read his expressions.

Jo had learned to recognize her signs.

A raised eyebrow could start an entire conversation.

A smile could answer a question before she ever opened the diary.

One evening, Jo looked at her and said,

"I think I'm getting better."

Mouna smiled.

She signed something.

Jo recognized it immediately.

Finally.

He laughed.

"That was rude."

She laughed too.

And somewhere along the way, their silence had stopped feeling like something they needed to fill.

It had become something they shared.

As their relationship grew, Jo began to notice how much Mouna had changed him.

He was more patient now.

He listened before responding.

He noticed things he once would have overlooked.

One evening, they were walking back from church when Mouna stopped and opened the diary.

She wrote:

You were different when I first met you.

Jo smiled.

"Different how?"

She wrote:

You were always in a hurry.

Jo laughed.

"That's still true."

Mouna shook her head and added:

Not anymore.

Jo looked at her.

Maybe she was right.

He had spent years rushing toward the next thing.

With Mouna, he had finally learned to slow down.

And he didn't want to rush this either.

Months passed quietly.

College became busier, but Jo and Mouna always found time for each other.

Sometimes it was only ten minutes between classes.

Sometimes it was a long walk after church.

Sometimes it was simply sitting together, sharing the diary between them.

One Sunday, Mouna wrote:

Do you still believe in true love?

Jo smiled.

He thought about the boy he had been years ago.

The boy who had searched for love in every new face.

Then he looked at Mouna.

He took the pen.

I don't have to believe anymore.

Mouna looked at him.

Jo added:

I know.

She smiled.

And somehow, those two words felt like everything he had been searching for.

After that Sunday, Jo began thinking about the future.

Not in the way he once had.

He no longer imagined some perfect love story waiting somewhere ahead.

He had already found something real.

Something imperfect.

Something quiet.

Something that had grown from a collision, a diary, a few chocolates, countless conversations, and ordinary Sundays.

One evening, Mouna asked him through the diary:

What happens next?

Jo smiled.

He looked at her for a moment before writing:

I don't know.

Then he added:

But I hope you're there.

Mouna read it slowly.

She smiled.

And beneath the fading evening light, Jo realized that for the first time in his life, he wasn't afraid of the future.

He was looking forward to it.

The final year arrived quietly.

Classes became more demanding. Friends started talking about jobs, higher studies and everything that waited beyond college.

Jo and Mouna were still together.

Some things had changed.

Others hadn't.

She still carried the diary.

He still played his guitar.

And Sundays still brought them back to the same church.

One evening, Jo found himself sitting there after Mass, watching the light fall through the windows.

He thought about the first time he had seen Mouna.

The staircase.

The apology.

The diary.

The chocolates.

Everything that had brought them here.

Then one thought settled quietly in his mind.

He knew what he wanted.

Now he only had to find the courage to ask.

Jo didn't tell Mouna about his thoughts.

Not yet.

Instead, he began paying attention to the little things that mattered to her.

The songs she liked.

The places she felt comfortable.

The moments when she needed someone beside her without asking.

He wanted whatever came next to feel like them.

Not something borrowed from a movie.

Not something perfect.

Something honest.

That evening, Jo opened the diary.

He wrote:

If you could keep one memory forever, what would it be?

Mouna thought for a long time.

Then she wrote:

I think I'd rather keep making new ones.

Jo read the sentence and smiled.

Maybe that was the answer he had been looking for.

He didn't want just one perfect moment.

He wanted a lifetime of ordinary ones with her.

A few days later, Jo met Arjun and the others after class.

They were talking about graduation plans when Arjun suddenly looked at him.

"You've been hiding something."

Jo smiled.

"What?"

"You've got that face."

"What face?"

"The face you get when you're planning something."

Jo laughed.

"Maybe I am."

Daniel leaned forward.

"Should we be worried?"

Jo shook his head.

"No."

He looked across the campus, where Mouna was walking with her friends.

For once, he didn't feel nervous.

He simply smiled.

There was still one thing he needed to do.

And this time, he wanted to do it right.

That evening, Jo returned home later than usual.

He placed his guitar beside the bed and sat quietly for a while.

Then he opened the drawer where he kept a few things he couldn't bring himself to throw away.

Old photographs.

A school wristband.

The first chocolate wrapper Mouna had given back to him as a joke.

And the little diary.

Jo smiled.

He opened it carefully.

Page after page carried pieces of their story.

Questions.

Jokes.

Apologies.

Memories.

He ran his fingers over the pages.

Maybe this was why he didn't want some grand, perfect proposal.

Their story had never been about perfect moments.

It had always been about the small ones.

Jo closed the diary.

He finally knew what he wanted to do.

And this time, he wasn't going to ask anyone else for advice.

The next morning, Jo met Mouna outside the library.

She smiled when she saw him.

He smiled back.

For a moment, he almost told her.

Instead, he asked, "Are you free on Sunday?"

Mouna opened the diary.

Church?

Jo nodded.

Then she wrote:

Of course.

Jo smiled.

"Good."

She looked at him curiously, as if she could tell he was hiding something.

Maybe she could.

But she didn't ask.

As they walked toward class, Jo looked at her and smiled.

Sunday was only a few days away.

And for the first time, he knew exactly what he wanted to say.

Sunday arrived quietly.

Jo reached the church earlier than usual.

The same place where they had spent so many Sundays together.

The same steps where they had talked about life, dreams and everything in between.

He sat there for a few minutes, holding the little diary in his hands.

Inside it were years of memories.

Then he heard footsteps.

Mouna was walking toward him.

She smiled.

Jo stood up.

For a moment, he simply looked at her.

He thought about the boy who had once dreamed of finding true love.

That boy had imagined fireworks, music and perfect moments.

But standing there now, Jo realized something.

He hadn't found love in a perfect moment.

He had found it in a thousand ordinary ones.

And today, he was finally ready to tell her.

Mouna looked at him curiously.

Jo took a slow breath.

Then he reached for the diary.

He opened it to a blank page and handed her the pen.

Mouna looked at him, waiting.

Jo smiled.

"I think I've been trying to find the right words for a long time."

He paused.

"But every time I try, they don't feel enough."

Mouna watched him quietly.

Jo took the diary back.

Then he wrote:

You taught me that love doesn't always need words.

He turned the page toward her.

Her eyes moved slowly across the sentence.

Jo looked at her.

"And somehow, you became the person I never want to lose."

Mouna's eyes filled with tears.

For once, she didn't reach for the diary.

She simply looked at him.

Jo reached into his pocket.

For a second, Mouna's eyes followed his hand.

Then he brought out a small box.

Her expression changed.

Jo smiled nervously.

"I've imagined this moment so many times."

He opened the box.

Inside was a simple ring.

"No perfect speech," he said. "No big promises about how everything will always be easy."

He took a breath.

"Just one question."

Jo looked into her eyes.

"Will you choose this life with me?"

Mouna covered her mouth.

Tears rolled down her cheeks as she smiled.

Then she reached for the diary.

She wrote only two words.

I will.

Jo looked at the two words for a long moment.

I will.

After everything they had been through, those two words felt bigger than any speech he could have given.

He smiled through his own tears.

Mouna closed the diary and held out her hand.

Jo gently placed the ring on her finger.

For a while, they simply stood there.

The church was quiet around them.

The same place where they had once shared their first Sunday coffee.

The same place where they had slowly learned each other's world.

And now, it had witnessed the beginning of something new.

Jo looked at Mouna and smiled.

All those years ago, he had asked God to help him find someone who would understand him.

He had never imagined the answer would arrive so quietly.

They stayed there for a little while longer, neither of them wanting to leave.

Mouna opened the diary one last time.

She turned to a fresh page and wrote:

Do you remember the first day we met?

Jo laughed.

"The staircase?"

She nodded.

"How could I forget?"

She smiled and added:

You almost killed me.

Jo laughed.

"I apologized!"

She shook her head, smiling.

He looked at her hand, the ring catching the soft light.

"Funny how everything started with an accident."

Mouna closed the diary.

Jo looked around the church.

Maybe some accidents weren't accidents at all.

Maybe some stories were simply waiting for the right moment to begin

Years later, Jo would still remember that Sunday.

Not because of the ring.

Not because of the words he had written.

But because of how quietly everything had happened.

There had been no crowd.

No stage.

No dramatic music.

Just the two of them, standing in a place that had slowly become theirs.

Mouna still kept the diary.

Its pages were filled now with years of memories.

The first apology.

The first chocolate.

Their Sunday walks.

Their terrible jokes.

Their little arguments.

And all the things they had learned to say without speaking.

Jo sometimes wondered what the younger version of himself would have thought if he could see them now.

He smiled.

Perhaps he would finally understand.

Love had been there all along.

He just had to learn how to listen.

That night, Jo sat beside Mouna with the diary resting between them.

He turned through the old pages slowly.

Every page carried a different version of them.

The awkward beginning.

The accidental meeting.

The first apology.

The first chocolate.

The Sundays.

The questions.

The answers.

The silence.

Mouna watched him smile.

"What?" she asked through a small gesture.

Jo shook his head.

"Nothing."

He closed the diary and looked at her.

"Just thinking about how far we've come."

Mouna smiled.

Jo reached for her hand.

For once, there was nothing left to explain.

They had spent years learning each other's language.

And somewhere along the way, they had discovered that love had its own

Later that night, Mouna placed the diary back in its usual place.

Jo looked at it and smiled.

"Do you know what I like most about this?"

She looked at him.

"The diary?"

Mouna nodded.

Jo shook his head.

"That it gave us a way to start."

She smiled.

He took her hand.

"Everything after that... we figured out together."

Mouna rested her head against his shoulder.

Outside, the city continued to move.

Cars passed.

Lights flickered.

People hurried home.

But inside that quiet room, Jo felt completely still.

For the first time in his life, he wasn't waiting for the next chapter.

He was simply grateful to be living it.

Years later, Jo would sometimes find himself thinking about that first day.

The staircase.

The fallen notebook.

The angry friend.

The girl who hadn't said a word.

He would laugh whenever he remembered how convinced he had been that love would arrive like a movie.

It hadn't.

It had arrived quietly.

Through a diary.

Through small chocolates.

Through Sunday mornings.

Through patience, mistakes, laughter and learning.

And through someone who taught him that silence was never the absence of a voice.

Sometimes, it was simply another way of speaking.

Jo looked at Mouna and smiled.

She smiled back.

And in that moment, he knew,

he had finally found the love he had been searching for.

That night, before going to sleep, Jo found the old diary on the table.

He opened it to the very first page he had written in.

The handwriting was uneven.

The words were simple.

But the memory was still clear.

He smiled.

Beside him, Mouna looked over.

"What are you reading?"

Jo closed the diary.

"Nothing."

She gave him a suspicious look.

He laughed.

"Just our beginning."

Mouna smiled and rested her head against his shoulder.

Jo looked at the diary one last time.

Some stories begin with a perfect moment.

Theirs had begun with a collision.

And somehow, that was perfect enough.

The next morning, life continued as it always did.

There was coffee to make.

Messages to answer.

Places to be.

Nothing about the world had changed.

And yet, everything had.

Jo looked at Mouna across the room.

She smiled.

He smiled back.

No grand words.

No promises that life would always be easy.

Just the quiet certainty that whatever came next, they would face it together.

Jo had once spent years wondering where his love story would begin.

Now he understood.

It had never needed a perfect beginning.

It only needed two people willing to stay.

And sometimes, the greatest love stories were the ones that began in silence.

Years later, Jo would still keep the diary.

It sat safely on a shelf, its pages worn from years of being opened and read again.

Sometimes Mouna would take it down and laugh at his old handwriting.

Sometimes Jo would find a forgotten note tucked between the pages.

Neither of them ever threw it away.

It had started as a simple way to communicate.

Somehow, it had become a record of everything they had built together.

Jo looked at Mouna.

"Do you remember what you wrote the first time?"

She smiled.

She knew exactly what he meant.

Mouna.

Just her name.

The first word of a story neither of them knew they were beginning.

Jo smiled.

Some stories are written with words.

Theirs had been written with silence

That evening, Jo and Mouna sat together in the quiet of their home.

The diary rested between them.

Jo opened it to a blank page.

For a moment, he thought about everything they had written before.

Then he picked up the pen.

He wrote:

I think I finally understand.

Mouna looked at him.

He continued:

Love was never about finding someone who could hear every word.

He turned the diary toward her.

It was about finding someone who could understand the things you couldn't say.

Mouna smiled.

She took the pen and wrote beneath it:

And staying long enough to learn.

Jo smiled.

He closed the diary.

Outside, the world was still noisy.

But between them, there was a silence that no longer needed to be explained.

It was simply theirs.

Theirs was a silent love.

Years had passed, but some things never changed.

Mouna still kept the diary.

Jo still played his guitar.

They still went to church together on Sundays whenever they could.

And sometimes, without saying anything, they would simply sit beside each other.

Jo would look at her.

Mouna would look back.

A smile was enough.

Because after everything they had learned, they no longer needed to explain every feeling.

They had learned each other's language.

They had learned each other's silence.

And somewhere between the words they wrote and the words they never needed to say, they had built a life together.

A quiet life.

A beautiful one.

Their silent love.

Years had passed since that Sunday.

Life had become fuller and busier in ways neither of them could have imagined.

There were responsibilities, work, ordinary problems and ordinary joys.

But some things remained unchanged.

On Sundays, whenever they could, Jo and Mouna still went to church together.

Sometimes they talked.

Sometimes they simply walked beside each other.

And sometimes, they sat quietly in the same place where so much of their story had begun.

Jo would look at her and smile.

Mouna would smile back.

Nothing more was needed.

They had learned that love did not have to be loud to be certain.

Sometimes, it was simply choosing the same person, again and again, every day.

The diary had grown old with them.

Its corners were worn, some pages had faded, and the handwriting had changed over the years.

But Jo still kept it.

One evening, he found Mouna reading through the old pages.

She smiled when she reached the first one.

Mouna.

Just her name.

The beginning of everything.

Jo sat beside her.

"You know, I still can't believe we started because I crashed into you."

Mouna looked at him and laughed.

She opened the diary and wrote:

You were very bad at first impressions.

Jo smiled.

"Apparently, I improved."

She looked at him for a moment.

Then wrote:

You did.

Jo closed the diary.

Some memories become stories.

Others become a part of who you are.

Theirs had somehow become both.

It was late that night when Jo woke up.

The room was quiet.

Mouna was asleep beside him.

He looked at the clock.

2:17 A.M.

For some reason, the time made him smile.

He remembered another night, years ago.

A younger Jo.

A guitar.

A quiet prayer.

A boy asking God to help him find someone who would understand him.

He looked at Mouna.

She stirred slightly in her sleep.

Jo smiled and whispered,

"Thank you."

He didn't know whether he was thanking God, life, or the girl sleeping beside him.

Maybe all three.

He closed his eyes.

For once, there was nothing left to search for.

Somewhere along the way, Jo had stopped searching for the perfect love story.

He had learned that love wasn't always found in grand moments.

Sometimes, it was a girl walking into a crowded room.

Sometimes, it was a staircase accident.

Sometimes, it was a little diary passed between two people who were learning how to understand each other.

Sometimes, it was a chocolate given without a reason.

Sometimes, it was sitting together in church on an ordinary Sunday.

And sometimes, love was simply staying.

Listening.

Learning.

Choosing.

Jo looked at Mouna one last time and smiled.

He had spent years searching for someone who would understand his words.

Instead, life had given him someone who understood his silence.

And perhaps that was the greatest love story of all.

THE END

Before you close this book, I hope you remember something.

Love isn't always loud.

Sometimes, it arrives quietly.

Sometimes, it looks like a conversation written in a little diary.

Sometimes, it looks like a chocolate handed over with an awkward smile.

Sometimes, it is simply someone sitting beside you when words aren't enough.

And sometimes, the most beautiful stories aren't the ones that begin perfectly.

They are the ones that grow slowly, through ordinary days, small mistakes, unexpected meetings, and countless moments that seemed insignificant at the time.

If you ever find yourself wondering whether a love like that still exists, I hope this story reminds you that it does.

Maybe your story hasn't begun yet.

Maybe you're already living it.

Or maybe, somewhere in the middle of an ordinary day, someone is about to walk into your life without either of you knowing what it will become.

Until then,

keep believing in the quiet things.

Because sometimes, the love we spend our whole lives searching for...

is simply waiting to be heard in the silence.

— The Silent Love